

It is like this. As a caterpillar, having gone to the tip of a blade of grass, then draws itself together to approach another one, in this way, the self (*ātman*), having dropped this body, rendering it unconscious, that self draws itself together to approach another body.

Brhadaraṇyaka Upaniṣad 4.4.3¹

The Subtle Body

1. Whose Body?

Darwin's famous rejection of God finds utterance in a pessimistic, if pithy arraignment of nature's cruelty. He wrote, "I cannot persuade myself that a beneficent and omnipotent God would have designedly created the Ichneumonidae with the express intention of their feeding within the living bodies of Caterpillars."² This parasitic wasp injects its eggs into the caterpillar; as it matures, the wasp larva slowly eats away from the inside its live womb, the caterpillar's body. The idea of an enemy within, a wasp taking over the hapless caterpillar from the inside, violating the body's boundaries, infiltrating its organs against the will of the body's proper owner strikes Darwin as too sinister to countenance. It's the stuff of horror movies, evoking images from the movie "Alien," with the strange, ugly creature bursting out of Kane's chest.

We, and Darwin, tend to think of our bodies as our own inviolable property, a self marked off from others by the boundary of skin that makes us each an individual with our own separate desires. Perhaps more disturbing still are those other infiltrating organisms that do not just devour bodies, but control also the mind and desires of their victim, like the horsehair worm that secretes neurotransmitters into the brains of crickets enticing them to commit suicide in waters they would normally shun—these mind controlling parasites elicit something more akin to an unconscious, visceral disgust in their sinister co-optation of something beyond the body, stealing away the mind and will of their victims. As if stealing the will and mind of a creature, even so humble a creature as a cricket, crosses a line. To bring it closer to home, we need only look so far as that best and ubiquitous of household pets, our feline companions. Joanne Webster, Jaroslav Flegr and others have painstakingly tracked how even for humans, for those infected with a parasite we get from our cats, *Toxoplasma gondii*, our wills and minds are not quite our own, but rather managed by these tiny infectious manipulators of consciousness.³

As Webster and her colleagues document,⁴ this tiny protozoa manages to alter dopamine production on a neuronal level, which, in the case of mice drives them to a reckless, fatal attraction for cat pheromones. For humans the altered brain chemistry brings its own kinds of recklessness; infected persons are far more likely, statistically, almost three times more likely, to get into car accidents.⁵ As Robert Sapolsky notes, the protozoa is also implicated in an increase in schizophrenia and suicide.⁶ A tiny parasite in

a human body becomes the author of human desires and actions. That such a tiny unintelligent creature could cause such deep volitional shifts in human behavior cannot help but give us pause. We think of our minds, our wills, as somehow our own, even more deeply our own than the bodies we possess. But what if the sense of self I habitually inhabit were somehow also an expression of more than just my familiar “I”? Here I am not suggesting that we consider the extensive and much-discussed influence we encounter through the self’s construction in its interrelations with other human selves and society.⁷ Rather, on a much more basic, bodily level, what if, indeed, my own desires are more than just me, are rather also the expressions of the various other beings that share my body space—the *Toxoplasma gondii*, the multiplicity of bacteria and viruses in the space of my body’s microbiome? Or indeed even something altogether lacking even the basic sentience of a protozoa—like the lead in drinking water which causes increased aggression, or the refined plant substance taken from a poppy to make a profoundly mind-controlling opioid? What if my will is simply the expression of one temporarily victorious puppeteer, among many of multiple agencies driving my desires?

For this chapter I point to an oddly similar appraisal of the human body that we find in a medieval Indian Tantric vision of the subtle body—similar in its displacement of human agency in favor of a multiplicity of not visible, hard to discover, but potent agencies directing human actions. This medieval Indian portrait of the human body that we see in the writings of the 11th century Hindu thinker Abhinavagupta takes the subtle body as the locus of a multiplicity of agencies, as a panoply of deities, that drive human choices. There is, of course, a big difference between gods inhabiting, directing the desires of a human body, and mindless parasites doing so through manipulations of brain dopamine levels, yet what they both point to is a displacement of agency for human subjectivity. For this chapter I address this key component of the subtle body within this medieval Indian context, namely that it operates as a way of acknowledging the multiplicity of agencies that make up human volition. The subtle body in this respect affords a recognition that the human is not master in its own house, but rather that the house itself, the subtle body, instead points to an expansive ecology with multiple expressions of agency directing human choices.⁸ What is so striking about this shift in perspective is that the very metaphor of “house,” Freud’s Western assumption of the body as some inert container, might not ever really work for something so complex and multiple as a human body.

In what follows below I first discuss Abhinavagupta’s panentheist conception of the subtle body and its implications for understanding the idea of the body generally for our contemporary world. I argue for an understanding of the subtle body as a way of acknowledging the multiplicity of agencies that make up human volition. With this, the subtle body for Abhinavagupta affords a way of allowing differentiation within his nondual philosophy, even as this capacity for difference is marked by human limitations. Following this, I examine a key problem the subtle body solves for an Indian context more generally, specifically, its function to carry the karma of person from one life to

the next. After this I address in greater detail Abhinavagupta's image of the subtle body as *puraṣṭaka*, the "City of Eight". On the heels of this we look at how Abhinavagupta's portrays the body as the abode of gods who direct its functions. Finally, by way of conclusion, we see that Abhinavagupta allows for a sense of unification of the self within the subtle body, simply through the use of the "I," the first-person perspective, as the "I" operates on multiple registers, embracing the multiple agencies that direct it as one's own.

Already it may be apparent that this conception of the subtle body is not particularly consonant with popular new-age versions of the subtle body, with their color-coded cakras pointing the way to spiritual enlightenment. And certainly, the subtle body also functions in other ways for medieval India; perhaps its most important function is as a means for explaining religious doctrinal points, such as reincarnation. It also operates as a mechanism for the kinds of magical powers, *siddhis*, that populate Indian religious traditions, and are entailed in this religiously shared Indian cosmology of proliferating ghosts and spirits.⁹ This proliferation of spirits, indeed, is implicated in the enmeshed network of multiple agencies overdetermining human choices. In any case, what is remarkable about this displacement of human agency is how surprisingly it parallels a modern Western scientific displacement of human agency. Even apart from infectious protozoans, a thrust of much contemporary human biology is an understanding that human agency is preempted by biological imperatives, the mechanical functions of neurons, neurotransmitters and hormones driving human behaviors, not at the behest of an individual's will, but rather more conspicuously serving the reproduction of genes. In this context Sapolsky is not an outlier when he suggests that given the mechanisms of human biology, free will is a difficult concept to consider.¹⁰ What these two very distant world-views separated by centuries and theology share is just this abrogation of human agency.

With these similarities, the theology that Abhinavagupta's medieval model carries may seem to us today as excess baggage, an unnecessary addition to the nuts and bolts of biology. I suggest, however, that Abhinavagupta's theological inscription of deities driving human action offers something more: a way of thinking about selves and bodies that can be valuable in our own current moment of planetary neglect. The panentheism out of which Abhinavagupta fashions his conception of the subtle body enfolds within it an upgrade for the idea of bodies, of matter. Not ever entirely dead, but imbued with a lively intentionality as the body's own entangled deities. The theology Abhinavagupta presents offers a perspectival shift into recognizing the body's claims to intentionality also, an intentionality typically only accorded to spirit. With this his model rejects a spirit-body duality where spirit is the true voice of the person possessing the body in favor instead of a continuum of an ever-expansive conception of what the idea of spirit, consciousness, might be in its highest expression as the "I," the pervasive sense of subjectivity animating all existence. The purest expression of spirit is simply the expansive embrace of a sense of "I" across bodies and deities.

Along these lines, I suspect that what is important about the understanding of the subtle body as made of deities is less its precise theological orientation of the body, an idea of this god or that god in this or that part of the body, and rather more the accompanying suggestion that various agencies drive human will, agencies with their own separate intentionalities. That Abhinavagupta offers different maps of which deities populate the various locations of the subtle body that do not agree in their details tends to suggest his own understanding of the subtle body concentrates less on which deity controls which part of human behavior and more as a nod to the body's inherent entanglements.¹¹ This panentheist theology is a way of underscoring a foundational liveliness to all that exists in our world. In this respect, Abhinavagupta's model of the subtle body with its multiplicity of agencies is surprisingly consonant with a new materialist reclamation of our world as not simply dead matter subject to human manipulations. Abhinavagupta's world view shares with new materialisms an acknowledgement of an ecology of beings in which we humans are materially embedded. The implicit panpsychism of much of new materialism finds a counterpart in this Indian model's basic panentheism, verging-on-panpsychism, highlighting the liveliness of the world, in this portrait of a body variously enacting the entelechies of different deities.

It is important here to emphasize that Abhinavagupta's cosmology derived out of the traditions in medieval India called the Mantramārga¹² and its consequent map of the subtle body is not quite the same as other images of subtle bodies that we find elsewhere in India's religious landscape, medieval and beyond. Apart from the fact that conceptions of what the subtle body looks like can vary dramatically,¹³ how the subtle body functions within a given cosmology also varies as well. We should be careful of assuming that even if the images of the subtle body differ from one tradition to the next, nevertheless, all portraits of the subtle body in India will offer the same understanding of how the subtle body operates, simply because the very concept of a subtle body in the first place is novel for a Western perspective. Abhinavagupta's panentheism entails some different functionalities for the subtle body than other models, for instance, models of the subtle body predicated on dualist conceptions of cosmology. Similarly, Buddhist philosophical conceptions need the notion of the subtle body to explain reincarnation, a key component of the historical Buddha's discourse, yet given the philosophical imperative of the Buddhist *anātma* doctrine to not have some substance-based soul hanging around, going from life to life, a Buddhist conception of subtle body at times starts to look like an idea of the subtle body as information, mere data conserved from one point in time to the next, without an accompanying unifying intelligence.

What marks Abhinavagupta's conception of the subtle body against these other conceptions, dualist and self-free, is, in the end, precisely his panentheism which folds a conception of consciousness with its intelligence intimately within bodies, not separate from bodies. He tells us, for instance, that "'that,' consciousness alone, is the highest ultimate body (*vapuh*) of all entities."¹⁴ Far from a dualist idea of a gulf between

consciousness and matter, here in contrast, consciousness itself is nothing other than a body. He does not entertain some idea akin to our familiar Cartesian split, which, even as we find this split in Sāṃkhya, Abhinavagupta rejects it. Rather, the model is one where consciousness itself molds itself into the multiplicity of beings with their bodies that make up the world. He writes, “on the back of the wall that is consciousness the picture of all beings becomes visible.”¹⁵ Consciousness itself is the stuff that makes up bodies, arranging itself in various ways. In this context, we hear him say that the ultimate expression of spirit and consciousness, the *Śiva tattva*, is also just a body: “The *Śiva* Archetype alone is the body of all things.”¹⁶ Very directly, he takes pains to clearly indicate his non-dualist cosmology to entail no difference between materiality and consciousness. Consciousness itself, in its highest, purest manifestation as the *Śiva tattva* is, in fact, just the body; the material component of the world is itself spirit. The concomitant corollary of this is that there is also no place where there is matter that is dead, entirely free of at least a latent capacity to express sentiency. As Abhinavagupta tells us, “Even the lifeless third person, if it sheds its lifeless form can take on the first and second person forms. As in, ‘Listen, o stones’ and ‘Of mountains, I am Meru.’”¹⁷ Here stones, which we and he typically understand as dead matter, are not ontologically bound to this lifeless state. By being addressed in the second person, he tells us, they lose their inert insentiency and take on the life that comes with being called “you,” through the second person address. Indeed, when we focus our attention on objects, the Buddha statue or the Catholic image of Mary on the altar, or even a favorite vase, the objects themselves appear to inhabit a kind of glow. Explaining the power of icons in a religious context usually invokes a notion that humans project human qualities onto objects. Abhinavagupta, in contrast, suggests that the stones or icons innately already possess a latent liveliness that merely comes to the surface by our address. The second example he gives, “Of mountains I am Meru” is spoken by the God Krishna to the warrior Arjuna in the *Bhagavad Gītā*; here Abhinava tells us, the mountain takes on the “I” feeling of the first grammatical person through this declaration, transforming it from object to subject. With this, no longer a dead configuration of stones and earth, it reclaims its deep essential nature as sentient subject.

So how does the subtle body play into this nondual fusion of matter and consciousness? We often think of the subtle body as being about transcendence, a way for the spirit to leave the body behind in some abstracted, disembodied and consequently more perfect, less entangled existence.¹⁸ Abhinavagupta’s model in contrast is very much about bringing things back to bodies, to materiality, no doubt, a materiality which is at base simply spirit in any case, yet one in which a lingering materiality as third-person object makes both interaction and multiplicity possible. What the subtle body does for Abhinavagupta is to allow this perspectival awareness to register the multiplicity that makes up the world. In relation to what the subtle body (*puryaṣṭaka*) does, he tells us,

“in the state of that type of I-consciousness, which belongs to the Lord ignorance is entirely removed. So the notion, “this is blue,” does not arise. Here that sort of lower I-consciousness needs to be developed which will not be

so spotless and rarefied as to entirely remove the knowledge of object as other.¹⁹

In order to relate to others we need something different than the highest awareness of nonduality; rather we need a lower sort of awareness. What the subtle body does is to afford us this lower awareness that makes it possible to differentiate others.²⁰ The subtle body is sufficiently enmeshed in the multiplicity of the world to register a difference between itself and another; it allows a person to notice some object nearby and to understand it as different from one's own self, to be able to interact with a blue something as outside of one's self, even if a truer gaze knows that its blue difference from me is merely provisional.

2. The Subtle Body and Transmigration

To get a sense of Abhinavagupta's mediating use of the subtle body, it may be helpful to look generally, if only briefly, at the subtle body's functions in an Indian context. Apart from Abhinavagupta's use of the subtle body to accommodate difference, to allow for a particular and limited self to act within a world of objects that she considers different from herself, probably the most predominant function of the subtle body within a Hindu context is as carrier for the karma that accompanies an individual from one life to the next. In this respect, the subtle body frequently functions as a vehicle for agency and responsibility for one's deeds, for one's karma in one body to take effect in some future life after the demise of the physical body. From the Buddha's many lives in the Jataka tales to Kṛṣṇa's declarations in the Gītā of his past lives, reincarnation is taken as a given, indubitable in the various Indian traditions in Buddhism, Jainism and Hinduism. Given the difficulty of explaining how something so ephemeral as deeds and intentions can be bound to a body that is not yet born, it is not surprising that what exactly it is that carries this karma varies considerably across different times and traditions.²¹ An early depiction of the process of transmigration in the *Bṛhadaranyaka Upaniṣad* from about the 8th century BCE paints the process of death as precisely the reduction of the multiplicity of agencies that was the body. When a person is dying, the text tells us, "he is becoming one, he does not see, they say; he is becoming one, he does not smell, they say; he is becoming one, he does not taste, they say; he is becoming one, he does not speak ..." and so on, through the variety of actions a living body does, including also thinking, hearing and comprehending.²² Śaṅkara tells us in his 8th century CE commentary on this Upaniṣad that:

becoming one means the subtle body (*lingātmā*) collects the person's activities...thus, when the operating deity (*devatā*) of smell ceases, smell becomes one with the subtle body, then the person does not smell, they say.²³

Here, the subtle body is a wrapper, a container for all the activities that end when the multiple agencies, the *devatās*, the operating deities of speech and sight and thinking cease as the person dies. This text also likens the subtle body to a caterpillar, but not like the unfortunate caterpillar that precipitated Darwin's atheism. In this image, like a

caterpillar (*trṇajalāyuka*) that pivots from one blade of grass to the next, the self moves from one body to the next.²⁴

Here, Śāṅkara points to the subtle body as the mechanism that solves the vexing problem of transference of a continuity of a particular self across the gap from one life to the next. However, we also see that the self, *ātman* can take on this role in an Indian context, without a subtle body. As Dasti and Phillips note, for the *Nyāya Sūtra* and its commentaries, the self, *ātman*, an immaterial entity, in this dualist philosophy acts as a receptacle for the *saṃskāras*, the collection of tendencies and karmas that we carry from one life to the next.²⁵ And as Wilhelm Halbfass observes, the Mīmāṃsaka Kumārila also understands that the effective causal quality of a properly performed ritual act, (*apūrva*) has the *ātman*, the self, as its locus.²⁶ Similarly, looking at early Upaniṣadic texts, Fred Smith points out the formulation of reincarnation through “a discarnate spirit essence” from one agent to the next life in what Smith notes as confirming “the doctrinal point of inherent separation of essence, ‘coded substance’, or ‘spirit’, and physical or observable matter.”²⁷ This is a dualism in the early tradition that Abhinavagupta’s Tantra tries to later rework into a monism. Smith points to this reincarnating entity as a “coded substance” in contrast to “physical or observable matter.” The spirit finds a physical body to inhabit. In this early case, the spirit is not understood as a subtle body, moving from life to life, but, as Smith remarks, still a substance, only a substance rather like code in his estimate. In contrast, Buddhism opts against an idea of self, against the idea of a substance moving from life to life, but keeps still a notion of karmic information as the impersonal, and non-permanent stream that allows a particular person to reincarnate. In this respect, as Alex Watson observes, Buddhists are not so dissimilar from Hindu Nāyāyikas in that both are dualists because both think of a non-physical part of us that exists beyond one life to go to the next.²⁸ In any case, as Sāṃkhya demonstrates, the subtle body is not a concept that arises only when a monism prevents the idea of self from serving as a particularized and limited carrier of karma. Īśvarakṛṣṇa’s *Sāṃkhya Kārikā*, with its own dualism akin to Cartesianism, tells us that it is the subtle body that transmigrates, not the self, and that the subtle body contains the ego and the mind and the senses, but not the gross, physical elements.²⁹ So, not the self per se, the subtle body here still has the elements of the person, including sense organs, but not the physical elements like earth and water.

Moreover, the subtle body does not arise only when a person leaves the body in death. We find in the *Tripurarahasya*,³⁰ a late medieval Sanskrit text, a tale of a king who wants to enter inside a mountain. The sage with him tells him to put his physical body in a nearby pit, so it will be safe, and then to use his subtle body to enter inside the mountain. The king does not know how to do this and wonders if he will die if he leaves his physical body. The sage laughs, instructs him to close his eyes, and then the sage enters the king’s body and separates the king’s subtle body (*liṅgatanu*) from the gross physical body.³¹ The sage puts the physical body aside, safe in a small pit. The sage then travels with his own subtle body and the king’s subtle body to the interior of the

mountain. We see with this both a physical body and a subtle body. The two are connected but separable. They mix and interact with each other. Both of these bodies are really bodies, part of the framework that makes up the body as a whole and there is a porous interface between the physical and the nonphysical body. Similarly in the approximately 14th century *Śaṅkaradigvijaya*, the sage Śaṅkara also uses his subtle body to leave his physical body and then inhabit the body of a newly dead king, so that he can win a debate with his philosophical opponent Maṇḍana Miśra. Here Śaṅkara displays his skills as a yogī: “occupying the subtle body (*ātivāhikaśarīra*), he, with the strength of his guru yoga, enters the body of the king.”³² His goal here is to use the dead king Amaruka’s body to experience what sex is like and at the same time not be guilty of breaking his celibacy vows as a monk.³³ The word for subtle body here, *ātivāhikaśarīra* is a “body that is extremely quick.” It is a body, with entailed materiality, but one which is light enough to travel to the sun and moon and the center of a mountain.

James Hartzell argues that the subtle body doctrine derives from early medical sources as the *karmapuruṣa*, literally “action-spirit,” which is the subtle body that comes into contact with the combined semen of the father and the blood of the mother when the child is conceived.³⁴ He describes the process in terms of key points in the physical body, the *cakras*, which act as portals:

The fundamental premise appears to be that our subtle body energy networks of centers (*cakras* or *padmas*) and channels (*nāḍīs*) and drops (*bindus*) is multidimensionally interlinked. During moments of sexual ecstasy certain channels of the subtle body open to these other dimensions, providing the routes whereby the (re-) incarnator can incarnate.³⁵

The mechanism for transmigration links the physical body with a co-habiting subtle body with its networks of *cakras* and channels, and also with some other kind of space where persons waiting to reincarnate reside until they find the routes to enter a body and be reborn. He also notes that the subtle body was not a sectarian concept aligned with only a particular school, but was rather accepted among different religious traditions.³⁶ Hartzell’s fascinating description highlights the problem of how something immaterial as the intentions and reverberation of past deeds can affect matter in a substantive way. It is not surprising then, that frequently for Hinduism the subtle body shows up ontologically as a quasi-physical substance,³⁷ which offers a permeability of mind and physicality.³⁸

The difficulty of trying to meld together the physical with the immaterial that the subtle body represents is demonstrated in the apocryphal story of the 19th cent founder of the Arya Samāj, Dayananda Sarasvati, pulling a corpse out of the Gangā river and cutting it open to see if he could find the *cakras* inside.³⁹ It is probably important to point out that ideas of the body in an Indian context map to a cosmology that does not quite adhere to the habitual boundaries between mind and matter in our familiar Cartesian conventions of what makes up the body. In a Sāṃkhya context mind (*manas*) and the sense of ego (*ahaṁkāra*) are not somehow sentient over and against the materiality of the earth and blood that comprise the body. The body as insentient matter is composed of earth,

water, fire, air and space along with other components such as sensory capacities, and also mind, intellect and ego. These latter are also not sentient, including mind. With its seamless mixing of the categories we term mind and matter, this Indian map of the body to some degree manages to sidestep some of the intractable oppositions that derive from a Cartesian bifurcation of mind and body.

Further, intertwined with this physicality, is breath, *prāṇa*—breath here is not simply oxygen moving in the lungs and out, but rather it exists also and primarily as a subtle flow in the body. For our Western context, breath, not alive itself, is a crude marker of sentience. Again, this does not entirely map to the Indian context, where once more, breath is no more a sign of sentience than is earth or blood, or intellect for that matter, depending on which philosophical system one follows. In Sāṃkhya, neither breath nor intellect nor the earth element of the body is sentient; only the Self (*ātman*) is. In contrast, for Abhinavagupta, insofar as the subtle body, made up of the five breaths (*prāṇas*) and the mind and intellect and so on—this subtle body, which transmigrates from one life to the next is enlivened by *vimarśa* through adopting a stance of subjectivity (*ahantā*), thus, it and the breath and the mind are sentient as well. In any case, more generally for Sāṃkhya in this respect, the gulf is between spirit and mind-body, not between mind and matter. So crossing the gap from body to mind is not the difficulty in this Indian context, as it might be for a Western Cartesian context since the mind, simply an offshoot of *Prakṛti*, Nature, is already fundamentally just matter. The trick is figuring out how to cross the gap between spirit to the materiality of mind-body.

Curiously, in Buddhism, which denies any idea of a self (*anātma* doctrine), or something like a spirit to contrast the mind-body, we still see a lingering materiality finding its way across lives. Even without the side of spirit, the *ātman* as Self to steer the path for a reincarnating person, or without Abhinavagupta's "I-ness" (*ahantā*), as a subjectivity for the subtle body to go from one life to the next, Buddhism proposes a mechanism as a stream for karma after the physical body dies. As Alexis Sanderson observes, even without a self, actions, seemingly ephemeral, also have a matter-based component, *avijñapti*,⁴⁰ that continues and carries forth the good or bad effects of the deed to ripen at a future time. With this, taking up a life as a soldier or hunter carries a karmic stream even when one is not killing other life, and also taking vows of Buddhist abstention has karmic fruit even when not actively practicing.⁴¹ This ripening is tied to the karmic stream of the person. So, while there is not a permanent self, still the karmic burden carries its own form of materiality, conducive to reappearing in the next life stream of a particular person. Even as Buddhism denies the idea of a self, it is still bound to a notion of a dualism of a material body and something quasi-physical, capable of jumping the gap of lives as a particular karmic stream of a particular individual to reincarnate, for instance, as the current Dalai Lama who remembers his last incarnation as the 13th Dalai Lama. The lingering materiality of a concept like *avijñapti* tends to work against an easy and increasingly familiar translation of Buddhism's no-self doctrine as replacing a substance-based self with the idea of self-as-process, self-as-information, popular in cognitive science conceptions.⁴² While Mark Siderits' tantalizing physicalist speculation

of rebirth as an organic equivalent of a Zip drive just before the final crash of the old computer to reinstall on the next birth aptly conveys the idea of self as information, the metaphor necessarily points to something he neglects, that is, the *thing* that is the Zip drive, its materiality as something like the subtle body containing the karmic information between lives.⁴³

Indeed, where the metaphor of self-as-information drops the corollary of a something like a subtle body, as it does for Siderits' attempt to interpret Buddhism in physicalist terms, there it also loses one of its major functions for Buddhism, the capacity to explain reincarnation. For instance, Thomas Metzinger discusses the biology of out-of-body experiences, referencing notions of "*prana*" and the "subtle body,"⁴⁴ noting that "OBE research now makes it an empirically plausible assumption that this subtle body does indeed exist."⁴⁵ However, his explanation diverges sharply from the emic perspective of Indian traditions, of Śaṅkara's *Digvijaya*, for instance, which understands the manipulation of matter—actually re-enlivening the king's dead body—by means of a person's subtle body entering and transforming that matter. Metzinger instead rejects an idea of "astral matter," concluding that the subtle body is the embodied brain's self-model, that it is "made of pure information flowing in the brain."⁴⁶ So this model supposes that the subtle body experience is a function of neuronal firing in a pattern that merely represents the self as out of the body. Certainly Śaṅkara's experience of living in King Amaruka's body amidst the king's harem in order to win his debate depends on something like "astral matter," his subtle body actually inhabiting the king's body. On the other hand, if it were only a question of information, given Śaṅkara's nondualist understanding of the self as all-pervasive, one might imagine it being possible to argue that the "information" he gathers from King Amaruka's body is nevertheless all-pervasively present, even in his own brain, without having recourse to a subtle body hopping into the dead king's body to experience sex, guilt-free. This of course, makes the narrative redundant. Why bother with this wonderfully fantastic story of hopping into a dead body if all this information is available within the easy reach of his own neuronal firing? As we saw earlier with Abhinavagupta, a nondual reality indeed erases the possibility for this story of two separate bodies, the king's and Śaṅkara's, since the concept of difference is not operative in a nondual perspective.

The function of the subtle body, then, is to offer the needed limitations to still engage in a world of difference in the midst of a nondualist cosmology that knows everything at once. The subtle body makes possible the idea of difference, in order to gain a sense of some blue thing as object, separate from the self, or a king's body in a harem that is different from the monk's celibate body. We do see also in Buddhism and Śaṅkara's Advaita Vedānta attempts to try and reconcile a nondual truth with the multiplicity of bodies and agents controlling those bodies by adopting a two-tier reality: on the one hand, the ultimate reality, the nondual simultaneous apprehension of all knowledge devoid of differentiation between various persons and things, and on the other, the ordinary reality, *vyavahāra*, where Śaṅkara actually needs a subtle body to hop into a dead king's body to win a debate. While the notion of a two-tiered reality does some

heavy lifting to help avoid the blatant, if only a mere seeming contradiction that what is actually true is not how we live in the world, it also brings its own messy conundrums, particularly around the idea of agency.⁴⁷ If there is only one nondual reality, then it becomes difficult to assign human responsibility for crimes and indeed, as Christian Coseru points out, difficult to engage in practice for spiritual transformation towards the goal of *nirvāṇa*. Discussing the ethical implications of a nondual perspective, he notes that the Buddha's emphasis on moral valuations of actions suggests that the Buddha favors a retention of a notion of individual responsibility.⁴⁸ With this, it appears, instead of the true, highest reality, we need more the world of ordinary life with its multiple differentiations, *vyavahāra*. In any case, the problems of agency that arise for Buddhist and Hindu nondualities start to look a bit like the difficulty the biologist Sapolsky faces with a nondualist materialism that understands human free will as an illusion of neurons and dopamine. Both these nondualisms, reversals of each other in terms of what they categorize as real—spirit or matter—fall prey to the problems of assigning agency. The subtle body with its capacity to mix up the matter that is the body with a limited version of spirit affords this capacity for differentiation of self and other and limited agency assignable to a distinct, limited person.

I want to point to one other important reading of the subtle body, which tangentially aligns with my reading of Abhinavagupta's use of the subtle body: its function as a mechanism for intersubjectivity. Geoffrey Samuel points out how ideas of the subtle body are very much also about the kinds of interrelation we have with our wider social and ecological context. Drawing especially from a Tibetan concept of the subtle body, he notes that it is also an avenue for interaction in ways that are not explicitly consciousness directed towards the objects of the world, but rather in a manner of flows between entities.⁴⁹ In this sense the subtle body operates as a means for relationality. Similarly, Jay Johnston talks about the subtle body in our current context as constituting a "radical form of intersubjectivity."⁵⁰ The notion that the subtle body offers a way of thinking about intersubjective relations is consonant with Abhinavagupta's conceptions of its function to create a space for differentiation.

Abhinavagupta's Conception of the Subtle Body

Abhinavagupta's conception of the subtle body is that it is simply consciousness, but consciousness which has become limited, contracted. He tells us:

the inherent nature of this person is that of pure consciousness which has become contracted into the subtle body, the City of Eight in the state of Emptiness, and has acquired the habit of wandering from body to body, life after life.⁵¹

The term he uses here for the subtle body in accordance with his Tantric lineage is *puraṣṭaka*, literally, the "City of Eight." We notice right away with the nomenclature that he uses, "City of Eight" that already the idea of the subtle body entails a plurality. Earlier we see "*sūkṣma śarīra*," literally, "subtle body," but here the very name of the subtle body references its inherent multiplicity. In any case, the subtle body, as the City

of Eight arises as a contraction of awareness, one that hinges upon deeper latent traces of a sense of limitation. Abhinavagupta describes this limitation in terms evocative of subconscious impulses that override what the conscious mind might say. He tells us:

So, thinking, I am “equal to *Rudra*, etc.,” and “I am that” [*Brahman*, Absolute] is fine, but to the extent that the latent residual impressions remain fully operative, it is reasonable that pride and anger, etc., will still arise.

Consciousness, which here possesses latent traces, herself creates limitation.

Consciousness is one alone, yet has a specific form where it consists of sound [form, taste] etc. which flow down and are absorbed, and from this the City of Eight is separated off from full consciousness.⁵²

Even if we might tell ourselves we are the pure highest awareness of divinity, the “I am that” of the Upaniṣads,⁵³ nevertheless, so long as deeper impressions of limitation remain latent in ourselves, anger and pride will still pop up against our will. His description explains with a psychological lucidity how his monism can incorporate a conception of a subtle body that is limited. Not full consciousness, the subtle body instead offers a sense of self as limited and differentiated from other selves. The subtle body also in his context is connected to the idea of Emptiness, the familiar Buddhist term of *śūnya*, which for Abhinavagupta’s context is understood as a kind of grounding space out of which the materiality of the world arises. Delineating the relationship that the subtle body bears to Emptiness, *śūnya*, Abhinavagupta says,

when “I-ness” is placed within Emptiness, it exists and is called the City of Eight. ... To which they say: “The subtle body is also present in the state of meditative absorption in that particular deep meditation (*samādhi*) which is a merger into Emptiness.” “I-ness” placed in Emptiness is the impeller, the one which agitates the five vital breaths and that “I-ness” takes the form of the function of the senses and it takes as its essence the City of Eight.⁵⁴

Abhinavagupta understands a stance of subjectivity, “I-ness” (*ahantā*) as key to enlivening the breath to take on its form as the subtle body, which wanders from body to body, life after life. The subtle body remains present even in a deep meditative state. So rather than the erasure of a sense of a subtle body in a state of Emptiness, for Abhinavagupta, there is instead a close linkage between the subtle body and Emptiness. The subtle body is also connected with the operations of bodily functions like smell and sight and the breath, *prāṇa*. The flow of *prāṇa*, breath, includes both a physical element and simultaneously a non-physical energetic component. This doubly configured understanding of breath, *prāṇa*, as both material and subtle contributes to make up the subtle body. Abhinavagupta tells us that the subtle body, this

“City of Eight here includes the five vital breaths plus the two groups of sense organs [organs of knowledge (*buddhīndriya*) and organs of action (*karmendriya*)]. By accepting the inner organs as one essential capacity to ascertain things, we have the third.⁵⁵

So the five vital breaths plus the two groups of sense organs make seven. The two groups of sense organs are the first group as the five senses, including the capacity to hear, see, feel, taste and smell. The second group, the five *karmendriya*, are connected to physical components of the body detailed in terms of function. They include the feet

as the capacity to move, the hands as the capacity to grasp, the anus as the capacity to excrete, the genitals as the capacity to reproduce and the mouth as the capacity for speech. The eighth component is the inner organ (*antaḥkaraṇa*), which includes lumped together the mind, intellect and ego. This thus gives us a picture of the subtle body, first, as made of the breaths (*prāṇa*). Additionally, the subtle body has the capacity to see and hear, as well as the capacity to grasp and speak, and also a capacity to think. This conception of the transmigrating subtle body with its powers to grasp and move looks like a bit more than a simple ghost, a transmigrating spirit that occasionally appears to the people left behind, and instead rather looks to have the powers of a poltergeist, grasping and speaking. Explicating the subtle body in more detail, Abhinavagupta tells us that “this City of Eight is an extremely subtle body”⁵⁶ and at the same time, it is

like the physical body, but does not have limitations in terms of its spatial dimensions. However, that [subtle body] is linked to time as a universal. ... The City of Eight does in fact have the nature of a body, because the great elements [fire, earth etc.] inhere in it. Also, here, in order to remove delusion, he uses the word “body” precisely to preempt the objection that the word “body” [with its physical implications] should not be applied here.⁵⁷

So the subtle body is like a physical body, but it does not have the same spatial limitations. It is connected to time as a universal, so it exists in time, but appears less constrained than the ordinary physical body. Even so, Abhinavagupta tells us that its rarefied condition should not be construed to mean that this subtle body does not partake of the materiality associated with bodies. Rather he emphasizes that the subtle body does indeed have the nature of a body. Still, as a body, it is not the same as the ordinary human physical body or other material objects. Describing the subtle body in its confluence with Emptiness, Abhinavagupta says,

these two, Emptiness and the City of Eight do have the nature of being an object. However, still there is a difference between these two and pots etc., because there is no association with the ability to produce pleasure and pain, since they lack contact with an external body. “Hence, in this way” he says, indicating that because of this difference, consequently they [physical bodies and pots] should not be considered [the same as] these two [Emptiness and the City of Eight].⁵⁸

So the subtle body is a body, yet not quite like the tangible familiar forms of matter, like clay pots, because the subtle body is not externally manifest. The picture we get of the subtle body is as a kind of quasi-materiality that includes a capacity for thought and even a capacity to move and grasp, along with sensory abilities, being able to hear and see. Still, this body lacks the tactile physicality of a clay pot, and that affords it a different status than an ordinary human body. There is also, however, some variance on what makes up the subtle body for Abhinavagupta’s tradition. He notes that:

some others say that the five subtle elements and the three inner organs are the City of Eight. Yet, because they include the five vital airs in the subtle element touch, the variety of viewpoints here turns out in reality to be no variety at all.⁵⁹

That is, the idea of the five vital breaths is already included in a different version of what makes up the subtle body, so Abhinavagupta tells us that however the eight is

configured, the five vital breaths are still included.

The five breaths, (*prāṇa*) carry links to various states of being. These are *prāṇa*, *apāna*, *samāna*, *udāna*, and *vyāna*. The *prāṇa* is the forward breath and is associated with the daytime and the waking state. The *apāna* is connected to nighttime, inwardness and dreaming. Curiously, Abhinavagupta appears to reverse the understanding of *prāṇa* and *apāna* that one finds typically in contemporary discussions of the breath in yoga practices, where *prāṇa* indicates the in-breath. For Abhinavagupta, in contrast, *prāṇa* points to the out-breath, since it is the breath which causes the external world to appear, while the *apāna* points to the in-breath, because it signals the person going inward and resting in the self.⁶⁰ The equalizing breath, the *samāna* is associated with deep sleep and also in states where one falls in a drunken stupor or a coma, or is chemically poisoned or is in a meditative awareness,⁶¹ while the up-breath, *udāna* is connected to an experience of transcendence.⁶² *Vyāna*, the all pervasive breath is connected to understanding the self to be the totality.⁶³

We can begin to see that the idea of the subtle body melds together elements of affect, various states of mind, with this, indirectly, emotions, cognitive deliberation, all then connected to bodily flows, and autonomic processes involved in sleep and bodily processes. The subtle body maps these flows of breath and mind and senses. In this way, wrapped in and through the physical body is a subtle body delineated by the movements of energy flows and functions; this model of body supplies the *cakras*, the subtle body centers, vortexes, which has become popular in the New Age West.

These subtle body centers link places in the body to mental and emotional functions. Abhinavagupta tells us the heart is connected to the function of creation and linked to memory and dreams, since these are also creative acts, while the subtle body *cakra* in the throat is connected to keeping alive in awareness the forms around us, and is connected to the waking state and things that are perceived as common to a variety of viewers.⁶⁴ These functions are not simply mechanical operations of an insentient body, however, but are expressions of an ever-present dense network of deities residing in various centers in this body, with the god *Brahmā* in the heart and the god *Viṣṇu* in the throat, linking the human with a plethora of other beings, all sharing the space of the human body.

The Gods in the Body

As a number of scholars have noted, the subtle body historically for India is not patterned on the organs of the physical body. Dominik Wujastyk points out that “the Tantric body is yet another example of a non-anatomical body”⁶⁵ and Gavin Flood offers an insightful analysis of the Tantric body as an overlay of a textual scriptural tradition.⁶⁶ This understanding of the human body as interlinked with a non-physical yet still somewhat material subtle body has a deep ancestry harkening back to Vedic

antecedents invoking various deities in the body. The *Taittirīya Brāhmaṇa*, in its “easy invocation”⁶⁷ of various gods in the human body describes it:

Let Agni, the god of fire reside in my speech. Speech is in the heart. The heart is in me. I am in immortality. Immortality is in the sacred verbal formula. Let Vayu, the god of wind reside in my breath. The breath is in the heart. The heart is in me. I am in immortality. Immortality is in the sacred verbal formula. Let the Sun god reside in my eye. The eye is in the heart. The heart is in me. I am in immortality. Immortality is in the sacred verbal formula.⁶⁸

The text continues on assigning different gods to dwell in different parts of the body, yet in this early formulation, not all of the components assigned to the body seem to be gods. For instance, the text invokes strength for the arms (*bala*), herbs and trees residing in one’s hair (*oṣadhivanaspati*). These elements do not ever quite take on the deification that we see happening for Agni as the god of fire, Surya as the sun god, or Vayu as the god of wind. Nevertheless, this early instance of reflecting the macrocosm in the microcosm points towards a deification of the various things that a human body can do, such as speech, seeing, hearing and also having strength (*bala*) and a fiery personality (*manyu*), even as we also see along with this what makes up the body, with earth (*pṛthivī*) as the element that makes for the material-body quality of a body (*śarīra*), and space residing in the ears. This pastiche of categorically dissimilar components linking the human body to the cosmos sets a template that echoes in later formulations of the subtle body as comprised of deities.⁶⁹

With Abhinavagupta’s Tantric articulation of the body in the 11th century we find the body parceled out into a framework of various deities governing its functions.⁷⁰ In Abhinavagupta’s *Dehasthadevatācakrastotram*, he praises a series of deities in the body, each associated with some aspect of human functioning. Beginning with Gaṇeśa, the elephant headed god, always first to be praised, Abhinavagupta sings, “I praise Gaṇapati, who is the *prāṇa*, the breath in the body, worshipped first in a hundred different philosophies, who delights in giving what one desires, adored by multitudes of gods and demons.”⁷¹ From Gaṇeśa he goes on to praise a variety of other gods, the god Vaṭuka as the *apāna*, the down-breath in the body, the god Ānandabhairava, a blissful form of the god Śiva, in the center of the heart, and the goddess Ānandabhairavī as the form of awareness (*vimarśa*) that makes the body sentient. The intellect (*buddhi*) is instantiated by the Goddess Brahmanī, as is the ego (*ahamkāra*) with the goddess Śāmbhavī, and the mind (*manas*) is the goddess Kaumarī. He proceeds to then assign goddesses to the five senses, Vaiṣṇavī as the goddess who hears our sounds, down to Lakṣmī who is the power in humans that smells. The components of the body that he outlines with this hymn loosely correspond to the elements that make up the subtle body.⁷² Containing the breath, the mental faculties of the mind, ego and intellect, collectively known as the inner organ (*antaḥkaraṇa*), along with the five sensory capacities, Abhinavagupta notes how each of these functions of the human body work through the power of deities who embody these functions. With this he effectively delegates the capacities we humans have to smell and think and breathe to a multiplicity of sentient others, beings who are gods making possible the variety of things

a human body accomplishes. The body, which is the material instantiation of human living, this body is fundamentally a plurality of subjectivities. The plurality we find for the subtle body is not surprising, since, after all, as we saw earlier, the subtle body is all about making a space for difference, for a multiplicity of others. It is what makes it possible to experience objects like a blue something different from one's self.

What makes this idea of the body as a plurality of agencies so especially different from a Western biological conception of the body driven by genetic predispositions, by the pull of the biome, by a biology barely or not at all conscious—is that Abhinavagupta's multiple agencies retain their own conscious intentions. These gods in the body have their own subjectivities. On the one hand, like Sapolsky's model which sees biology driving human choices rather than a governing human person making choices—here also, the idea of an individual person's human will as the force directing the body is abandoned. On the other hand, instead of impersonal forces, like neuronal dopamine or even the manipulations of *Toxoplasma gondii* as the forces driving human behavior, instead, here gods direct the body. Lakṣmī, the traditional goddess of wealth does the smelling that the body performs; Indrāṇī is the force that sees; Śāmbhavī directs my choice to drive fast or slow, and so on. Abhinavagupta's theological shift adds an element of subjectivity, conscious intentionality to the various agencies directing the body.

Abhinavagupta offers also a different map of gods directing the functions in the body than the one we find in the *Dehasthadevatācakrastotram*. In his philosophical opus, the *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarsinī*, he talks about the various gods in the body as a ladder leading up to the highest awareness. Referencing particular points in the body as energy centers, focally potent places in the body, Abhinavagupta tells us:

In this way, the god *Brahmā* is in the heart; *Viṣṇu* is in the throat; *Rudra* is in the palate. *Īśvara*, the Lord, is in the space between the eyebrows. *Sadāśiva* is upward in the cranial opening at the soft spot on the top of the skull, and *Śakti*, the divine feminine Energy, has the nature of being in no particular abode. These are all the supreme reality in a six-fold body. The six forms serve as a cause making a ladder in the human body up to the level which is the supreme reality. [Utpaladeva] explains these forms designated by the scriptural texts as the inherent essential nature of each of these places, the heart and so on⁷³

The physical body is the abode of Gods and what happens on the subtle level, in this case on the level of particular deities is replicated in this mundane lump of flesh as the material instantiation of particular energies. Thus, the creator God *Brahmā* is located in the heart, because the heart is understood as the place in the body where we create ideas, while Rudra is in the palate, because the palate represents the space where speech dissolves upward into silence. The essential nature of these places in the body, the heart and so on are the functions ascribed to particular deities. These gods make a ladder, both physically and metaphysically in the body. The several *cakras* lining up along the spine allow our physical bodies to demonstrate the energies and intentions, the affective impulses of various gods in the cosmos. This macrocosm-microcosm

linkage between the human body and the greater world around us is not a new idea for Abhinavagupta; we saw it also in the Vedic “easy invocation” where the trees and herbs are understood as the hair of the human person; where the god of fire, Agni, is invoked to reside in human speech.

In this way, Abhinavagupta offers deities as representations of particular affective and sensory bodily functions, here and as we saw earlier, in the *Dehasthadevatācakrastotram* where, for instance, our familiar experience of smell is the Goddess of wealth offering fragrant flowers. With this he points to a radically different model of what it means to inhabit a human body than our routine, implicitly dualist, assumption that the body is a mere inert lump of flesh to manipulate, as simply the “house” for what is actually real, our consciousness, or soul.

Along these lines, as I noted earlier, I suspect that what is important about the understanding of the subtle body as made of deities is less its precise theological orientation of the body, an idea of this god or that god in this or that part of the body, and rather more the accompanying suggestion that various agencies, with their own separate intentionalities, direct human choices. The *Dehasthadevatācakrastotram* tells us that the god Ānandabhairava resides in the heart, while the *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* places the creator god Brahmā in the heart. That Abhinavagupta offers different maps for the gods in the body suggests his own understanding of the subtle body concentrates less on which deity controls which part of human behavior, and more on the map itself as a displacement of human control, a recognition of the human as embedded in a topology of multiple agencies.

Deities point to particular bodily affects which congeal intentionality and function and sensory experience. Not fundamentally directed by the person or the person’s mind or will, this conception of deity references intentionality within a schematic of sensory appreciation and desires. The idea of deity gets at the types of affective bodily processing that bypass the mind’s chatter—the involuntary crinkling of the nose in the face of a nasty smell, the body’s hair rising at an unexpected scary turn in the movie. Abhinavagupta’s use of the concept of deity allows for intentionality and the autonomy of the body’s affective experiences in ways that can be expressed as different, sometimes contradictory, to the storyline that the mind repeats to itself about the self. Thus, in this Indian conception, the story the mind tells itself is the function of two components, the *manas*, mind chatter, and *ahaṁkāra*, the ego. What these Indian texts consider as the ego and the mind map nicely to what cognitive scientists like Merlin Donald⁷⁴ and George Lakoff and Marc Johnson⁷⁵ point to as the cognitive executive function of the mind. Operating alongside these two, but with different trajectories, we find other, different intentional and autonomous affective processes of the body, the memory of smells, as Proust so eloquently demonstrated, the heightened mood of a meditative state. Their separate, rich life is highlighted by not reducing these functions to mechanical bodily processes, but affording them instead the sentience of deity.

Brian Massumi also references this disjunct between what our minds say and the richness of our body's contradictory expressions in his seminal article, "The Autonomy of Affect."⁷⁶ He notes that our conscious expressions arise by dint of inhibition and he calls for a deeper examination of this multiple richness in the affects of the body. Massumi proposes that we understand this rich and contradictory expression of affect as a kind of virtual reality. Abhinavagupta instead reads the multiple registers of affect in the body as a theology. This theology of the body demonstrates affective states as a variety of deities. They inculcate a sense of multiple agencies, with intentionalities that are not always congruent with each other, or with the ego and mind.

In a sense we might say that theology here registers a kind of respect for the affective processes of the body. Locating gods in the body is a way of acknowledging that not all in this human body is under the sway of that seeming uniquely human crowning glory of discursive mental thought that we call the mind. Sentiency, will, desire, pop up all over the body, not just as hand-maidens of the mind. This theology of the body, moreover, proposes these multiple affective registers in a way that does not dwell, to either lament or rejoice, on the subsequent disappointment and loss of the sovereignty of the ego and its free will. So while Massumi strives to find a model to understand the complex, refractory affective flows of the body in a language of the virtual, Abhinavagupta instead reads this complexity of multiple affective flows through a lens of forces of deities with their own conscious trajectories. In this respect, this panentheist theology affords a foundational liveliness to the multiplicity of agencies that make up the body, here referenced in Abhinavagupta's map of the subtle body, which sees the body itself as an ecology of beings, materially embedded.

Conclusion

By way of conclusion, I will offer what I see as Abhinavagupta's response to a particular complication that follows from the idea of a multiplicity of deities directing human choices. How is it that these multiple agents, gods in the body, do not make us into schizophrenic multiplicities, a self splintered into a profusion of voices and intentions? In terms of the biology from a Western perspective, we do already find something like a jungle of desires and intentions. Antonio Damasio tells us that we are made up of a multitude of cells, each undergoing its own encounters of birth, development and death. Damasio says that individual cells also have things like desire and will, that is the desire to stay alive. Even as he notes that it is odd to think of cells having desire the way we have desire, nevertheless, he tells us, that this is still the case.⁷⁷ Similarly, Patrick McNamara suggests that a disunity of self goes all the way down to our genes, drawing from Haig's genetic research indicating that even for the fetus in the womb, maternal and paternal genes have opposing operations, with clashing drives, and they consequently compete for expression.⁷⁸ Tim Morton, looking to Lynn Margulis' work on endosymbiosis, points out that a host of life forms already live within us. Even a basic component of our cell structure, the mitochondria is a relic symbiont, an other living entity with its own intentions, merging with our cell structure.⁷⁹ Abhinavagupta, on the

other hand, does not leave us with a fragmented multiplicity of vying agencies. Rather, the unity of the self arises in the midst of the multiplicity that is the subtle body with its accompanying deities, simply through reclaiming subjectivity, through embracing the first-person perspective. It is precisely the stance of subjectivity, “I-ness” (*ahantā*) which assimilates the multiplicity of the body with its various pulls. In laying out a possible argument against his conception of the subtle body, he says:

One may object here — of course it is possible to declare the City of Eight as the manifestation of the Self since the City of Eight has this capacity to remain unseen in the normal way that we see a pot etc. But why is there the unnecessary addition of the “I” following from this imposed onto the City of Eight? [Utpaladeva] expresses this idea saying, “in the belief, the concept of 'I'”. To this objection [Utpaladeva] replies, “belonging to it, the 'I' alone.” The word “alone” indicates that the “I” which appears to be an extraneous addition should be accepted as necessary to the City of Eight. In the absence of the perception of the “I,” in fact, these attributes, [the subtle body etc.,] are accompanied by pure unadulterated ignorance. If the host of entities and things, blue etc., are not seen as belonging to the Self, then they would not have the capacity to manifest, but they do appear.⁸⁰

The “I” (*aham*), the sense of subjectivity is not an extraneous addition to the subtle body. The subtle body is instead the attribute of subjectivity. As we saw earlier, the subtle body arises through the contraction of pure consciousness. This consciousness is the sense of “I”, the *ahantā*, “I-ness.” This sense of “I-ness” enlivens the subtle body; with this it is what unifies the multiplicity of gods directing the body. This host of gods in the body, that Abhinavagupta describes as a ladder, as we saw earlier, function to bring just this awareness to the person, that the self is not different from the highest God. Indeed, following on his description of the gods in the body that we saw above, Abhinavagupta, quoting a line from the grammarian Bhartṛhari, tells us that this self, in the end, is itself the multiplicity of what exists, consisting of all, all the gods in the body; this one which experiences everything:

Dividing the Self by the Self, having created entities of different types, he places them separately; the lord of all, consisting of all, is the enjoyer, the experiencer in dreams, who sets things in motion.⁸¹

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³ McAuliffe, Kathleen. *This is your Brain on Parasites*. Boston: Mariner Books, Houghton Mifflin Harcourt 2016, 57-82.

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⁵⁵ (McAuliffe 2016) p.63. Sapolsky notes 3-4 times more likely in his interview with Edge TV (R. Sapolsky n.d.).

⁶ (McAuliffe 2016) p.75.

⁷ What I will not do here is articulate for this context of the subtle body, the helpful and well-trod understanding of construction of a self through its engagement with an external social world. Much has been written about how identity, agency and desires are enacted via the social world we inhabit, through advertising (I'm thinking of Pierre Bourdieu's work particularly, though much else is certainly available) through cultural expectations of gender (I think of Judith Butler here), and through our understandings of self in relation to others as a kind of inter-being with others (I think of Catherine Keller's brilliant work here). This understanding has also been followed in relation to ideas of the subtle body (I'm thinking of Gavin Flood's work, in Flood, Gavin, *The Tantric Body: The Secret Tradition of Hindu Religion*. New York: I.B. Tauris 2006).

⁸ Here Freud's monochromatic Darwinian deterministic drives as everything just the id, is replaced by an expansive multiplicity.

⁹ See Fred Smith's excellent and expansive treatment of the various spirits that possess humans, for instance, p.194, in (Smith 2006).

¹⁰ (Sapolsky, Stanford Lectures, lecture 25 2010) Stanford Lectures. Lecture 25, beginning 3:09 minutes, especially 5:34 minutes, 25:38 minutes. Also, (Sapolsky, Sapolsky on Free Will 2018), beginning 0:40 minutes.

¹¹ We will look at the differences in these models below.

¹² See Alexis Sanderson's seminal article on this nomenclature, (Sanderson, Śaivism and the Tantric Traditions 1988).

¹³ See (Samuel 2013, Johnston 2013), also, (Heilijgers-Seelen 1994)

¹⁴ Abhinavagupta, *ipvv*, vol.3, p.257: "Tad eva ca sarvabhāvanām pāramāthikam vapuḥ." The "tad" here refers to the "tat" in the verse a few lines earlier on which Abhinavagupta comments, referencing "matur," "belonging to the subject." I.e., the subject who is conscious, since as Abhinavagupta notes immediately in his commentary, that the causality we find in the world cannot be attributed to insentient objects, but only to consciousness: "jaḍe pratiṣṭhitaḥ kārya kāraṇa bhāvo na upapadyate, api tu cidrūpa eva"

¹⁵ *ipvv* vol. 3 p.257: Tad bhitta prṣṭhe ca sarva bhāva citra nirbhāsa iti

¹⁶ *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* vol.3 p.257: śivatattvaṃ hi sarva padārthānām vapuḥ.

¹⁷ Abhinavagupta, *Parātriṃśikāvivaraṇa*, downloaded from S.D. Vasudeva's Indology E-text webpage: <http://homepage.mac.com/somadevah/etx/PaTriViv.txt>, page 212: narātmāno jaḍa api tyaktatpūrvarūpāḥ śāktaśaivarūpabhājo bhavanti, śṛṇvata grāvāṇaḥ [cf Mahābhāṣya 3.1.1; cf Vākyapadīya 3 Puruṣasamuddeśa 2], meruḥ śikhariṇām ahaṃ bhavāmi [Bhagavadgītā 10.23].

¹⁸ We see this idea in the Bṛhadaraṇyaka Upaniṣad, (Bṛhadaraṇyaka n.d.) 4.4.4, where the dead person takes on a better body, that of a celestial being (gandharva, pitṛ), just as a goldsmith takes a piece of gold and molds it into a more beautiful shape. Here, like Abhinavagupta, however, we still keep an idea of the body.

¹⁹ *ipvv* vol.3, p.282: Tena aham bhāvena ajñatā sarvathaiva tirodhīyate iti punar api nīlam idam iti na prarohet. Tatas tādṛgaparo >ham bhāvo >tra niṣektavyo yas tatra jñatām nirmalatayātiraskartuṃ na śaktaḥ

²⁰ Note that Torella points to Utpaladeva's conception of two types of self-awareness, (aham pratyavamarśa), a pure one related to ascertainment of I as pure consciousness creating the field, and an

impure one that relates the I to its manifestation as object, as subtle body (puryastaka) as prāṇa or breath, and as the body (deha) in (Torella, IPK 2002), p.132, v.1.6.4.

²¹ See Wilhelm Halbfass' extensive discussion of karma in the context of transmigration in (Halbfass 1991), especially pp.291-346.

²² (Bṛhadaraṇyaka n.d.) 4.4.2: "ekībhavati na paśyatīty āhuḥ | ekībhavati na jighratīty āhuḥ | ekībhavati na rasayatīty āhuḥ | ekībhavati na vadatīty āhuḥ | ekībhavati na śṛṇotīty āhuḥ | ekībhavati na manuta ity āhuḥ | ekībhavati na sprśatīty āhuḥ | ekībhavati na vijānātīty āhuḥ." Following speech, he does not hear, does not think, does not touch, does not comprehend. See also (Olivelle 1996), p.64 who translates this differently, as "he is sinking" and (Radhakrishnan 1989), p.270, with whose translation of "ekībhavati" as "becoming one" I concur.

²³ (Bṛhadaraṇyaka n.d.) BrhUpBh_4.4.2 ekībhavati karaṇajātaṃ svena liṅgātmanā/... tathā ghrāṇadevatānivr̥tttau ghrāṇamekībhavati liṅgātmanā tadā na jighratītyāhuḥ

²⁴ (Bṛhadaraṇyaka n.d.) 4.4.3 : tad yathā tṛṇajalāyukā tṛṇasyāntaṃ gatvānyam ākramam ākramyātmānam upasaṃharati | evam evāyam ātmedaṃ śarīraṃ nihatyāvidyāṃ gamayitvānyam ākramam ākramyātmānam upasaṃharati | |

²⁵ (Dasti and Phillips 2017), 88.

²⁶ (Halbfass 1991), 304; also (Aklujkar 2004) 705.

²⁷ (Smith 2006) 208.

²⁸ (Watson 2014), 176.

²⁹ (Larson 1969) 272.

³⁰ Tripurarahasya, 12.72-96, (Kavirāja 1927). See also the translation by (Saraswathi 2006) p.104-106.

³¹ (White 2011), 153-156 also talks about this phenomenon of one person entering another person's body, where the yogi is capable of directing the entered body like a puppet.

³² (Vidyāraṇya 1972), 10.104b: "mahipasya varṣma guruyogabalo 'aviśadātivāhikaśarīrayutaḥ". See also (Madhava-Vidyaranya n.d.).

³³ See a discussion of the process as described in the writings of the 20th century Tantric thinker Gopinath Kaviraj in (Biernacki 2018).

³⁴ (Hartzell 1997) 574 in Suśruta 3.1.16, also 569-70. Note that he contradicts Surendranath Dasgupta here who says there is no connection.

³⁵ (Hartzell 1997) 559.

³⁶ (Hartzell 1997) 573.

³⁷ Joseph Alter also notes that hatha yoga postulates a theory of the body where "even the most subtle sheath is constituted of matter," (Alter 2015) 138.

³⁸ Fred Smith also points out that the Indian conception of self includes an idea of fluidity, divisibility and penetrability as features of personhood. (Smith 2006) 37.

³⁹ Nevermind that ideas of the subtle suggest that it departs with death so that by the time the Swamiji recovered the corpse from the river, the subtle body with its cakras would have already departed on its journey to the next world.

⁴⁰ Perhaps not so unlike Kumārila's *apūrva*.

⁴¹ (Sanderson, Sarvāstivāda and its Critics: Anātmavāda and the Theory of Karma 1994) 38-39.

⁴² (Damasio 2010), 8.

⁴³ (M. Siderits 2001), 311. See also Dan Arnold's critique of the notion in (Arnold 2014), 4, 246, footnote 11.

⁴⁴ (Metzinger 2009), 257.

⁴⁵ (Metzinger 2009), 257.

⁴⁶ (Metzinger 2009), 257.

⁴⁷ See Sthaneshwar Timalsina's brilliant understanding of assimilating two levels of reality within subjectivity of the self through a Kashmiri model, using Abhinavagupta's work on rasa theory to understand how an actor can occupy two-tiers of absolute and ordinary, both at the same time in (Timalsina 2016).

- ⁴⁸ (Coseru, "Freedom from Responsibility: Agent-Neutral Consequentialism and the Bodhisattva Ideal" 2016), *passim*, especially 102.
- ⁴⁹ (Samuel 2013), 251.
- ⁵⁰ (Johnston 2013), 240.
- ⁵¹ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 310: śūnyapuryaṣṭakasaṃkūcitasamvitsvabhāvaḥ, saṃsaraṇaśīlaḥ
- ⁵² (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 286-7: "Rudrādes tulanam" ity ādau ca "so >ham" iti tāvat saṃskārapūrṇa eva aham iti parāmarśāt garvakopādyudayā yuktāḥ. Svakṛtasamkocasaṃskāravatī yā cit, tanmayatayā pralīnam apasāritaśabdādirūpa viśeṣam ekam iti puryaṣṭakāntarāder bhinnam.
- ⁵³ Taken from the *Īśa Upaniṣad*, verse 16. (Olivelle 1996), 80-81.
- ⁵⁴ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 335-6: śūnyāhantām ākṣipya vartamānaḥ puryaṣṭakaḥ iti uktaḥ... Yad āhuḥ 'līnaśūnyasamādhāvapyāste liṅgaśarīraḥ |' iti. "Tathā ca" iti yata evaṃ, tata evaṃ yojanā sā śūnye 'hantā prāṇādiperikā akṣavṛttirūpā puryaṣṭakātmiketi.
- ⁵⁵ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3 p. 334: Ubhayaḥ api ca ayaṃ yonyantarasañcārī puryaṣṭakaśabdavācyaḥ yato 'tra prāṇādipañcakam indriyavargau dvau niścayātmikā ca tṛtiyā svīkṛtāntarāntarā dhīrvyayate.
- ⁵⁶ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3 p.306: "puryaṣṭakātmātātyantasūksmadeha eva vā." In the text he is quoting Utpaladeva's commentary and he links the subtle body here, as we saw earlier to Emptiness.
- ⁵⁷ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3 p.306: kālaviśeṣeṇa ca śarīrivat niyatena pārimītyabhijñā yo 'vacchedas tadrahitah; sāmānyakālayogas tu tasya api asty eva... Puryaṣṭakasya dehatā asty eva mahābhūtaiḥ samanvayād iti tad api iha na vacanīyam iti mohavyapohanāya śāṅkodbhāvanārthaṃ dehagrahaṇam.
- ⁵⁸ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol. 3, 307: tayoḥ astu prameyatā, tābhyāṃ tu anyat pramīyate ghaṭādi bāhyaśarīreṇa asaṃparke bhogasamvādayogāt. "Ata eva" iti yato 'nyat na pramīyate tābhyāṃ, tataḥ.
- ⁵⁹ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3 p. 336: Yatas tanmātrapañcakamantaḥkaraṇaṃ ceti kecana puryaṣṭakam āhuḥ sparśatanmātreṇa prāṇādisvikārāt, tata eva atra pakṣavaicitrye vastuno na vaicitryam iti.
- ⁶⁰ Quoting Utpaladeva he tells us "in the creation of objects the expansion and unfoldment of the objective world belongs to the prāṇa, while the dissolution of the world is a process belonging to the subject alone." (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 344: arthānāṃ sarge 'pi asau prāṇasya pravṛttiḥ pramātauḥ pralaya eva. Lakṣmanjoo also notes this reversal of function for prāṇa and apāna. This reversal is in keeping with Olivelle's translation of the *Upaniṣad*, where he also translates prāṇa as out-breath (Olivelle 1996), 100.
- ⁶¹ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 337.
- ⁶² (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 335-6.
- ⁶³ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 349.
- ⁶⁴ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 309.
- ⁶⁵ (Wujastyk 2009), 200.
- ⁶⁶ (Flood, *Tantric Body: The Secret Tradition of Hindu Religion* 2006), 13.
- ⁶⁷ My translation of the well-known name for this portion of the text called *laghu nyāsa*.
- ⁶⁸ (Taittirīya Brāhmaṇa n.d.), 3.10.4-3.10.9: Agnir me vāci śritaḥ | Vāghṛdaye | Hṛdayaṃ mayi | Ahamamṛte | Amṛtaṃ brahmaṇi | | My translation of this basic formula which substitutes a different deity for each verse.
- ⁶⁹ We also see hints of this above in Śāṅkara's depiction of the five sensory functions like smell and so on collecting in the subtle body, even as Śāṅkara's adherence to his nondualism tends toward precluding a sensibility of various deities.

⁷⁰ Gavin Flood points out that Tantric conceptions of the body rely on a notion of an emanationist cosmology which is implicitly and often explicitly pluralistic in (Flood, *Tantric Body: The Secret Tradition of Hindu Religion* 2006), 29.

⁷¹ (Abhinavagupta, *Dehasthadevatā* n.d.) vs. 1. See also (Flood, *Body and Cosmology in Kashmir Śaivism* 1993), 305-308. My translation alters these two only slightly.

⁷² There is not an exact corresponce. The subtle body for instance is comprised of the five breaths, whereas in this hymn Abhinavagupta only mentions the prāṇa and apāna breaths.

⁷³ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 309: Tata eva brahmahṛdayo viṣṇukaṇṭho rudratālur Īśvarabhrūmadhyāḥ Sadāśivoudhvabrahmarandhro 'nāśritātmakaśaktisopānoparipadaḥ kāraṇaṣaṭkavigrahaḥ parameśvaraḥ iti hṛdayādisvarūpābhidhānena sūcita āgamiko 'rthaḥ

⁷⁴ (Donald 2002).

⁷⁵ (Lakoff and Johnson 1999).

⁷⁶ (Massumi 2002), 23-45.

⁷⁷ (Damasio 2010), 37.

⁷⁸ (McNamara 2014), 37.

⁷⁹ (Morton 2013), 139.

⁸⁰ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 281: Nanu adarśanayogyam puryaṣṭakādi prakāśamānatayā nāma saṃbhāvyatām ghaṭādivadeva, tasya tu kim ahaṃ pratītyā adhikayā yena uktaṃ "pratītau" iti. Āha "tasyaiva" iti. "Kevalam" iti iyadadhikamavaśyam aṅgikāryam. Ahaṃ pratītyabhāve hi sa eva "śuddhājñatvasahita" iti ātmatayāyo na dṛśyate bhāvavargo nīlādīḥ, sa naiva prakāśeta, prakāśate ca asau.

⁸¹ (Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* 1985), vol.3, 309: 'pravibhajyātmanātmānam sṛṣṭvā bhāvān pṛthag vidhān | sarveśvaraḥ sarvamayaḥ svapne bhoktā pravartate ||'. Quote taken from Bhartṛhari's *Vākyapadīya* 1.140. (Bhartṛhari 1977)